

Expository Writing

Week 4

DESCRIPTIVE ESSAYS

If the reader is unable to clearly form an impression of the thing that you are describing, try, try again!

- The descriptive essay provides details about how something looks, feels, tastes, smells, makes one feel, or sounds.
- It can also describe what something is, or how something happened.
- use a lot of sensory details.
- The essay could be a list-like description that provides point by point details.
- Examples:
 - A descriptive essay could describe . . .
 - * a tree in my backyard;
 - * a visit to the children's ward of a hospital

HOW TO WRITE A DESCRIPTIVE ESSAY?

- A descriptive essay is a form of academic writing that is built around:
 - describing people,
 - describing places or buildings and
 - describing objects.
- To **describe something in a vivid and particular manner**
 - Today, the wispy wet water is streaming down from the sky, like honey slipping off a spoon.
 - Drops of rain exit the pillowcases, drowsily float like feathers, soar in many directions.
 - It is raining today; the crystal clear raindrops hit the ground silently.

DESCRIPTIVE ESSAY

- The focus is to create a vivid mental image for the reader. By using intricate details and expressive language, you invite readers into a sensory experience, making them feel a part of the story.
- Descriptive writing can take the form of newspaper articles, book reports, research papers, accounts of a single event, travelogues, and memoirs of a personal experience.
- **Write an Introductory Paragraph.**
- Start with a hook like a rhetorical question, an interesting fact or an anecdote. Next, provide the context/background/setting/characters for your essay. Then write the three point **thesis statement**, followed by a **transitional hook**.
- **Write Three Body Paragraphs.**
- Each paragraph in the body of the essay should focus on its own distinct issue that helps develop and support the thesis statement in your topic sentence. Make sure you're using factual information to support your thesis and are maintaining an objective point of view. Each body paragraph should begin with a topic sentence. Parse out details in each body paragraph. Specific examples always make more of an impression than generalizations.
- **Write a Concluding Paragraph.**
- This paragraph should only contain information you've already presented earlier in the essay. Use this space to restate your thesis, summarize your supporting points from each body paragraph, and wrap up your essay.



Types of Detail:

Take note: you always describe your sense of sight (we do this naturally), so when trying to write with more *sensory details*, focus on adding more of the other four senses. Yes, some of the "specific" details listed are visual things (there is overlap between the two types of detail in this respect).

Specific Details:

"It was a sunflower: it was tall and sturdy with a stalk that made a crooked arch-shape. The center of the flower head was large and brown, full of little seeds, and surrounded by many thin floppy petals that were not bright yellow, but a dull mustard color."

Sensory Details:

"The flower had a thick, grizzly stalk and bushy leaves covered in what looked like a thin layer of fuzz. Because it was so tall, it wobbled forward and back in the wind, always with its head facing the most direct rays of warm sunlight. The faint smell of pollen, sweet but fishy at the same time, hovered around the plant."

Types of Detail:

We'll think of detail in two different ways:

Specific Details:

"Specific" means *clearly defined or identified*, so "specific details" are concrete words and phrases used to describe something.

"It was a sunflower: it was tall and sturdy with a stalk that made a crooked arch-shape. The center of the flower head was large and brown, full of little seeds, and surrounded by many thin floppy petals that were not bright yellow, but a dull mustard color."

Sensory Details:

These are the words that express the feelings of our five senses: descriptions of how things look, taste, smell, sound, and feel.

"The flower had a thick, grizzly stalk and bushy leaves covered in what looked like a thin layer of fuzz. Because it was so tall, it wobbled forward and back in the wind, always with its head facing the most direct rays of warm sunlight. The faint smell of pollen, sweet but fishy at the same time, hovered around the plant."

FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE

- "that news hit me like a ton of bricks,"
- **Figurative Language:** involves some imaginative comparison between seemingly unlike things.
- **Simile:** A comparison using "like" or "as" (ex: She sings like an angel.)
- **metaphor:** A comparison of two unlike things that suggests a similarity between the two items. (ex: Love is a rose.)
- **Personification:** Giving an inanimate object or animal human attributes. (ex: The cow spoke to me, or the rock lies on its back.)
- **hyperbole:** An exaggeration. (ex: That building can touch the clouds.)
- **idiom:** An expression that cannot be understood from the individual meanings of its elements. (ex: kick the bucket or under the weather)
- **Descriptive Language**— Language intended to create a mood, person, place, thing, event, emotion, or experience.
- **Imagery** - visually descriptive or figurative language, especially in a literary work that appeals to the five senses: hearing, taste, touch, smell, and sight



OUTLINE STRUCTURE

- **Introduction**
 - Write a hook (rhetorical question, interesting fact, anecdote) that helps your reader relate to the senses you're tapping into.
 - Provide some general background about the thing you're describing.
 - Form a thesis statement that makes a claim (but may not necessarily include an argument).
 - Transitional hook
- **Body paragraph: Physical Description**
 - Provide a topic sentence introducing the subject.
 - Give an in-depth physical description of the subject.
- **Body paragraph: Contextual Description**
 - Describe your subject within its given context, like its physical surroundings or temporal environment.
- **Body paragraph: Emotional Description**
 - Describe how the subject emotionally or mentally affected those who interacted or experienced it.
- **Conclusion**
 - Restate your thesis about the subject's description.
 - Consider the subject (and its description) outside of what you've already mentioned in the essay. How might it apply to other people or society at large?



VIVID DESCRIPTIONS AND ENGAGING LANGUAGE

- **My favourite place**
 - As I walk down the dirt road that leads to the farmhouse in the countryside, I am greeted by the sweet smell of hay and the sound of crickets chirping in the distance. The rolling hills that surround the farm are covered in lush green grass and dotted with wildflowers of every colour. The old wooden barn and weathered farmhouse are a testament to the many years of hard work and love that my grandparents have put into this land. I can't help but feel a sense of peace and belonging when I am here, surrounded by and the memories of my family.
- **"The City at Night"**
 - The city comes alive at night, its streets bathed in the glow of neon lights and the hum of activity. The air is filled with the scent of roasted peanuts and hot dogs, and the sound of honking horns and chatter of people fills your ears. The towering skyscrapers loom above you, casting long shadows that stretch across the sidewalks. The city bustles with a dynamic energy that captivates its inhabitants, evident through the towering skyscrapers, ceaseless activity, and an undeniable sense of vitality pulsating through its streets.

